

OpenDev.Studio

SMART LEGAL CONTRACT SYSTEMS · BUILT FOR THE REAL WORLD

The Bridge

How OpenDev keeps the contract live.

A smart legal contract methodology for projects where money, time, approval, and risk move while the work is underway.

1

The problem

Most construction contracts cannot keep up with their projects.

A contract gets drafted in months three through six of a deal, signed at month seven, and then ignored until something breaks. By the time something does break — a Change Order someone disputes, a payment someone holds, a delay someone wants compensated — the contract is a binder on a shelf and the project has moved on without it. The parties argue from memory. The lawyers argue from fragments. The audit trail is whatever each party kept in their own files. Nobody has the same picture of what is true.

This is not a drafting problem. It is an administration problem. Often, the contracts are written well enough. They simply describe a static moment, signed once, while the project they govern moves continuously. The gap between the document and the day grows wider with every month of construction, and the gap is where disputes live.

OpenDev is built for the gap.

2

The thesis

Nothing changes by accident.

Every event that touches a deal — a Pay Application, a Change Order, a substitution, a delay, a compliance lapse — has a defined route. Every term in every contract has a defined tier. The contract and the project move together because the contract knows what kind of event it is being asked to absorb, and the parties agreed up front to the procedure that absorbs it.

When something happens, no one has to invent a process. The process is already named. The routing is already decided. The ledger updates the same way every time, and every party sees the same thing.

That is what it means to keep a contract live.

3

The Contract Ledger

The Contract Ledger is the deal's accounting in real time. Not just for money, but for everything the contract allocates: time, risk, approvals, compliance, change, and close-out.

It runs in seven sections.

Economic. Every dollar in or out. Pay Applications, retainage, allowances, contingencies, Change Orders, fee invoices, retainage release.

Schedule. Every day owed or earned. Notice to Proceed, Substantial Completion targets, Excusable Delay extensions, long-stop dates, critical-path milestones.

Risk. Every allocation and every shift. Indemnity carveouts, insurance requirements, force majeure declarations, cause attribution on Change Orders.

Approval. Every gate, certification, approval, rejection, and signature. Pay Application certifications, Change Order approvals, ASI logs, formal amendments.

Compliance. Insurance certificates. Lien waivers. Regulatory filings. Statutory deadlines that quietly pass and erase rights nobody knew they had until they needed them.

Change. Every Change Order, every adjustment, every substitution. With the routing that produced each one preserved.

Close-Out. The final-period workflow at the end. Punch list closure, retainage release, final acceptance, audit log lock.

An action can touch more than one section at once. An approved Change Order hits Economic, Schedule, Risk, and Change — four ledger sections, one event, one routing. The platform writes to all four. The visibility is shared.

4

The Bridge

The Bridge is the working table between the signed contracts and the moving project.

It is the artifact that makes the methodology computable. One row per operative term, across every contract running concurrently — on a build-to-suit development that means four contracts at once: Construction, Design, Owner's Representative, Lease. The description in plain English. The tier. The ledger sections that term touches when it executes. The party who carries the consequence. The dollars and the days when dollars and days apply. Those contracts may involve up to five active seats: Owner, Architect, Contractor, Tenant, and ORPM.

A typical four-contract development may produce hundreds of rows.

The Bridge is what translates the language of the contract into the operational reality of the project. Lawyers write the contract. The Bridge classifies it. The platform administers it. The parties live inside it.

Without the Bridge, the methodology reduces to good intentions. With the Bridge, the system runs.

5

The four tiers

Every term in every contract gets classified into one of four tiers. The tier determines what kind of action that term can take when something happens during operation, and what level of approval is required to change the term itself.

Tier A — Informational. Forecasts, estimates, pending exposure, draft calculations, and items raised but not yet decided. A submitted-but-unapproved Change Order. A disputed claim awaiting resolution. A flagged compliance gap. Tier A items appear in the record so nothing gets lost. They do not bind any party until they move through the required procedure.

Tier B — Operational. Day-to-day actions that produce records but do not change the contractual state of the deal. A Pay Application submission. A lien waiver collection. An ASI log. A meeting minutes upload. Tier B is the volume of the system — most actions, most days, all evidentiary, none amending.

Tier C — Contractual State Change. Actions that update the binding state of the deal. An approved Change Order. Owner approval of amount payable under a Pay Application. A force majeure declaration. A Substantial Completion certificate. Tier C events change what the parties owe each other. They require defined approval workflows. They leave permanent marks on the ledger. The contract says the approved procedure updates the ledger, and the parties signed up to that mechanism when they signed.

Tier D — Formal Amendment. Structural terms that cannot be modified by ordinary action. Indemnity provisions. Risk allocations. Term length. Rent formula. Cost-sharing formula. The 75/25 split between Building Cost and Tenant Improvement. The Tier D universe is the deal's spine. To change a Tier D term, the parties must execute a formal amendment — the same level of effort as renegotiating that piece of the deal entirely.

The tier system protects the parties from accidental amendment. A team running a project cannot change the structure of the deal by approving Change Orders. The structure is structural. Operations operate. The lines are clear before the work begins, and they hold.

6

Three worked examples

Example one — Pay Application Flow (Tier B → limited Tier C)

Week four of construction. The Contractor submits the first Pay Application through the platform on the 25th of the month. Standard line items. Mobilization, foundation excavation, footing pour. Total billed: \$312,400. Retainage held at 10%.

The platform routes the submission to the Architect, who reviews against observed progress and certifies within four business days. The Owner's Representative logs an advisory recommendation in the Approval Ledger as a Tier B operational entry. The Owner approves on the eighth business

day. Payment processes per the wire schedule. The audit log timestamps every hand-off.

The Pay Application is a Tier B operational event. It updates the Economic and Approval ledgers and may trigger the existing payment obligation under the contract, but it does not amend the contract or change the structure of the deal. The next Pay Application will arrive in roughly four weeks and follow the same procedure, certified by the same parties, recorded in the same ledger, every time, for the life of the project.

This is what most days look like. Tier B operational. Volume. Routine. The methodology earns its keep here not by being dramatic but by being quiet.

Example two — Change Order (Tier C)

Month six of construction. The Contractor's structural steel supplier issues a revised quote. A regional supply disruption — mill outage in the Midwest, freight rerouting through alternate ports — has pushed steel prices 22% above contract pricing. The order has to go out this week to hold the schedule. Two hundred seventeen thousand dollars. Cause attribution under this deal: market disruption beyond Contractor's control, allocated to the Owner under the contract's escalation provision.

The Contractor submits a Change Order. The platform routes it to the Architect for scope review and the Owner's Representative for cause attribution. The Architect compares the supplier's revised package against the contract documents and confirms the steel scope is unchanged — no design issue, no scope creep, the cause is external. The Owner's Representative pulls the supply disruption documentation, verifies the freight cost analysis, and recommends approval.

The Owner approves the Change Order at \$217,000.

The platform updates four ledger sections at once. Economic absorbs the increase. Schedule holds — no time impact on the steel order itself. Risk logs the cause attribution. Change adds the row. Every party sees the entire chain in real time, including the Tenant, who under the lease's open-book provision watches the largest Change Order of the project move through procedure with full visibility.

This is Tier C. Contractual State Change. The deal owes new dollars now. The ledger reflects it. The audit log timestamps every approval. The Bridge holds the new state of the deal alongside everything that came before it.

Example three — Formal Amendment (Tier D)

Month eleven of construction. The Contractor proposes a roofing substitution. The price is roughly even. The schedule impact is neutral. On its surface, this looks like an ordinary product substitution — a Tier C Change Order.

But the warranty terms shift risk. The specified product carries a 20-year manufacturer warranty with full replacement coverage. The alternate carries a 15-year warranty with prorated replacement. Over the life of the building, that difference reallocates roof failure risk between Owner and manufacturer.

The Architect flags the warranty difference. The Owner's Representative applies the contract's sharpening rule: Change Orders that shift risk between parties route to formal amendment, not ordinary Change Order, regardless of size.

The substitution moves through the formal amendment process. Both parties execute the amendment within ten business days. The Bridge logs the substitution as Tier D — a structural change properly handled.

This is what the tier system protects against. Without it, a quiet warranty shift would have approved as Tier C, and twelve years later, when a roof issue arises, no one would remember that the warranty was different from what was specified. With it, the structural change goes through structural process. The deal's spine stays intact.

7

Who should care

OpenDev is built for owners, tenants, contractors, architects, owner's representatives, lawyers, lenders, and operators who need the contract record to keep up with the project.

Owners building projects that take more than a year and involve more than two parties. Tenants signing build-to-suit leases for buildings that do not yet exist. Contractors who want change, delay, and payment questions resolved when the facts are fresh. Architects who do not want certifications relitigated months later. Owner's representatives who want compliance work to leave a record. Lawyers who want the contracts they draft to operate after signature. Lenders who

want to see whether the financed deal is still the deal they underwrote.

The methodology is not for everyone. It is for parties who want clarity on the front end and are willing to do the work to get there. It rewards discipline. It punishes shortcuts. It is built on the assumption that the parties at the table actually want the deal to work, not just to win the argument when the deal breaks.

8

How to engage

There are three ways to start.

Play through the methodology. The Negotiate showroom at opendev.studio walks a visitor through the eight beats of contract negotiation, from a seat of their choosing, in fifteen to twenty minutes. The visitor leaves with a personalized record of the negotiation as they experienced it. No installation. No live LLM. The whole thing is scripted because the methodology is the point.

Request a private briefing. For lawyers, lenders, developers, and operators evaluating OpenDev for a real project, a thirty-minute briefing covers the methodology in detail with reference to the project under consideration. The briefing is conversational. Bring questions.

Pilot inquiry. OpenDev is currently being applied to active development deals. Inquiries about applying the methodology to a specific project — build-to-suit lease, ground-up development, complex multi-party work — are welcome. The fit conversation is short, honest, and bidirectional. We are not for everyone, by design.

Reach out at opendev.studio, by email at tcbmem@gmail.com, or through Telegram at [@tcbmem](https://t.me/tcbmem).

To engage, visit opendev.studio.